of a person. It was a matter of great relief to me to see that the Congress party was like a family during the Yatra. I made friends and got acquainted with like-minded people. Now wherever I go, I meet people who know me and those that I know. In every programme across the country, now the common reference point is that ‘we participated in Bharat Jodo Yatra together’. The Yatra has created a strong sense of affinity for the party and party workers for me.

The temporary nature of our lives and the lessons from it is one of the shared experiences for the yatris, but the experiences that were even more overwhelming were those we shared with the people we met on the way. On so many occasions, as we were walking in the heat, people would come to give us water just to show they cared. Sometimes the shopkeepers would refuse money when we purchased food or water from them and kindly ask us to accept the items as a token of their support for our cause.

For me, the most profound conversations were with children on the way. I remember meeting a very excited child shouting slogans. I asked him if his parents had brought him to the Yatra. I was filled with such pride when the child answered, ‘Actually, no, I brought my parents here.’ I consider children to be great educators—after all, they are our future. In my political journey, I have witnessed how quickly and powerfully children catch on to slogans when the ‘*Azaadi Azaadi*’ slogan was taken up by them across Delhi and even India. I got to observe this again during the Yatra. Children would clap and cheer as we began our journey. Once the Yatra gained more visibility through the media and social media, we met children in different parts shouting the slogan: ‘ ? ,
(Who will bring hearts closer? We will, we will.)’ It reminded us that the future still held great possibilities for this nation.

Hope is a powerful emotion and while we all wish to stay hopeful in life, how many people can actually say that they have seen hope ignited like fire in people’s eyes? I believe my fellow yatris and I can definitely say we have. As we moved across the country, we observed how the Yatra rebuilt the bridges of hope with love, humanity and non-violence, connecting people with people. Irrespective of the weather, be it day or night, be it any